

SAMURAI AND FOOT SOLDIERS

THE SIEGE OF OSAKA CASTLE

The Sengoku period in Japan was a 150-year era of civil conflict when rival *daimyo* (feudal lords) and their samurai vied for power. The Siege of Osaka castle in 1614–15 was the climax and conclusion of this turbulent era.

The *daimyo* Tokugawa Ieyasu, effective ruler of Japan from 1600, took the title of shogun (military dictator) for the Tokugawa family. The impressive castle at Osaka was the power base of the rival Toyotomi clan, whose leader, Toyotomi Hideyori, had a better hereditary claim to the shogunate than the Tokugawa. In 1614, Ieyasu invented a pretext to attack the Toyotomi, assembling an army possibly 190,000-strong. *Daimyo* and samurai discontented with Tokugawa rule flocked to join Hideyori in Osaka. They included many masterless samurai, the *ronin*. An experienced warrior, Sanada Yukimura, oversaw the strengthening of the castle's defences, ordering the digging of moats and the building of an earthwork barican outside the tall stone walls.

The siege began in November 1614. First the Tokugawa captured various strongpoints in the country around Osaka. They then confronted Sanada's earthworks, but their siege weapons – a handful of imported European culverins and several hundred Japanese or Chinese artillery pieces – were powerless against thick earth walls. The Tokugawa decided to attack. They surged forward in their thousands, the *ashigaru* (peasant foot soldiers) armed with long pikes or arquebuses, the samurai, dismounting, wielding spears and swords. It was an impressive sight, the samurai arrayed in elaborate armour, the foot soldiers displaying a mass of fluttering flags attached to their backs by poles. But when they mounted ladders to scale the walls, the attackers were cut down by arquebuses fired through loopholes at the top of the fortifications. Where they breached the outer wall they found themselves trapped in front

of inner defences and fired down upon from all sides. The Tokugawa, suffering heavy losses, abandoned their assault and retreated to siege lines where they camped in the bitter winter cold. The defenders nestled inside the castle, living off plentiful food stores.

A TREACHEROUS TREATY

Toyotomi Hideyori then made the fatal error of negotiating a peace deal with the Tokugawa. He was tricked. As soon as the armies dispersed, the Tokugawa ordered the Osaka moats filled in and the earthworks levelled. By the time fighting resumed in the spring of 1615 – after Ieyasu pressed another spurious cause for war – Osaka castle was no longer defensible. The reassembled Toyotomi forces instead sought to pre-empt a siege by winning victory in the open field. The climactic encounter, known as the Battle of Tennoji, came in early June. The Toyotomi adopted a plan in which part of their forces would use a flanking movement to take the enemy from the rear, and then a reserve would enter the battle at the crucial moment. But this strategy was too complex for their loosely coordinated army. Many of the *ronin* attacked at will, and arquebusiers assigned to the reserve opened fire without waiting for orders. In the midst of a chaotic struggle Sanada was killed and his severed head displayed to the demoralized troops. A belated sortie by the garrison from the castle, led by Hideyori himself, was driven back through the gates. As Tokugawa cannon battered the stone walls and parts of the castle caught fire, Hideyori committed *seppuku* (ritual suicide). The Tokugawa shogunate was destined to last another 250 years.

